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Sheikh with a joint declaration, bringing India and Pakistan back to the dialogue table, something that the Obama Administration had been advocating. Then she got an assurance from India on the two nuclear sites for US companies as well as the End User Defence Agreement which ensures that the US defence industry can bag a chunk of an estimated \$40 billion of defence purchases India is expected to make. So armed with a slew of good news deliverables when she appeared with External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna at Hyderabad House, dressed in a pristine white suit with a pearl necklace, a beaming Hillary declared, "Cooperation between our two countries will be the driver of progress in the 21st century". And Hillary told her hosts that she is committed to

go a mile more for the relationship than what the Bill Clinton and Bush regimes did. So the new strategic dialogue that the two countries have unveiled will have an institutional framework for cooperation between the two foreign ministers on areas such as non-proliferation, counter-terrorism and military cooperation. But there are road blocks ahead on issues such as non-proliferation. Though Hillary backed India's commitment to move forward on a verifiable Fissile Material Cut-off Treaty during the negotiations, the country may be in for some pressure to sign the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty.

In between Twitter updates and nursing a fractured elbow coupled with a sore throat, Hillary kept her official engagements to a bare minimum as she tried to reach out to a cross-section during her five-day visit. From a meeting with business leaders in Mumbai, a visit to a green building in Gurgaon to interacting with a young audience at Delhi University, the tech-savvy secretary of state did everything with a lot of élan. In contrast to her predecessor

Condoleezza Rice, who was more business-like, Hillary used her also-ran presidential candidate skills to disarm her Indian interlocutors. Behind closed doors, she carried along her blueprint of smart diplomacy, camouflaging even the tough messages with niceties. The tag of an old friend of India as a former co-chair of the India Caucus in the US Senate did help as her hosts readily opened many doors for her, even on the contentious WTO negotiations, with India indicating that it is willing to cut a deal.

Three pacts were also signed during the visit, including the Science and Technology Cooperation Agreement, and a Technology Safeguards Agreement which will facilitate the launch of a US-licensed spacecraft and will safeguard protected technologies and data of both countries. The End Use Monitoring Agreement, which is the third agreement, has run into a major controversy with the Opposition hurling charges of a sell-out. The agreement was framed by the US Congress to ensure on-site inspection of US defence equipment and to ensure that it is not transferred to a third party. Even though India has managed to negotiate with the US that the country will determine the time and place, the problem will be for equipment like radars which are installed at a particular defence base. Besides, analysts caution about some restrictive post-sales clauses of the defence equipment which may force India to adhere to US terms on using hardware and may curtail its right to utilise it according to its own operational needs. It will also be dependent on the US for spares of weapon systems and America may determine if military equipment can be used for defensive or offensive use.

Even though Singh flagged the issue, the US was non-committal on supporting India's candidature for a permanent seat in the UN Security Council. Despite a strategic relationship, almost two dozen Indian government companies are still on the US's entity list which prohibits trade in sensitive technology. There were some consolation prizes though. Hillary handed over an invitation from US President Barack Obama to the prime minister for the first state visit to Washington on November 24. While Hillary has gone back with a lot of return gifts from India, the visit fell short on deliverables. While India and the US can make a good couple, the problem is that for now, their diplomatic relationship has become a high-cost-low-yield affair with shades of a client-state approach, which needs some urgent course correction. ■

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